

Plato's Cave

From The Republic of Plato (c. 375 BCE), Books VI and VII. Rendered in modern English for this lesson.

The Republic is a dialogue. The form is common in ancient Greek philosophy: two or more speakers question each other, working towards an answer together. Plato wrote dozens of dialogues, and almost all of them have Socrates, his teacher, as the main speaker.

In the Republic, Socrates spends a long evening at the house of a wealthy Athenian, arguing about justice. The question is what justice really is, and whether a just life is happier than an unjust one. To answer it, Socrates builds an entire imaginary city in argument.

The passages that follow come from the middle of that argument. Socrates is speaking to a young man called Glaucon, Plato's elder brother. He uses two connected images, the sun and the cave, to describe the philosopher's education and the world the philosopher comes to know.

Glossary

Forms (or Ideas) the unchanging, perfect realities of which the things we see in the world are imperfect copies. Examples: the Form of Justice, the Form of the Triangle, the Form of Beauty.

The Good the highest of the Forms. The source of being for the Forms and of the mind's power to know them. Plato calls it 'beyond being.'

Visible / intelligible the visible world is what we see with the senses; the intelligible world is what we grasp with the mind.

1. Why the Good must be glimpsed indirectly

Republic VI, 506d-e

Asked to say what the Good itself is, Socrates refuses to answer directly and offers, in its place, 'a child of the Good' — an analogy.

I would rather not speak about the Good itself today. That subject would be too high for our present enquiry. What I will speak about instead is what seems to me to be the child of the Good — the thing most like it.

Republic VI, 506e (modern rendering)

Question

Why won't Socrates speak about the Good directly?

2. The Sun analogy

Republic VI, 507a-509c

Socrates argues that sight requires three things: a healthy eye, a visible object, and a third element — light — whose source is the sun. The sun does two jobs at once: it makes seeing possible, and it makes the things seen exist and grow. The Good plays the same double role in the intelligible world.

Let me put it this way. The sun is to vision, and to the things vision sees, what the Good is to the mind, and to the things the mind knows.

Republic VI, 508b (modern rendering)

The Good is the source not only of knowledge but of being itself:

What gives truth to the things we know, and the power of knowing to the knower, is the Form of the Good. The Good is the cause of both knowledge and truth, in so far as we know anything at all.

Republic VI, 508e (modern rendering)

And finally, the famous claim that the Good is beyond being itself:

In the same way, the Good is the cause not only of our knowledge of things, but of their very being. And yet the Good is not itself among those things that simply are. It lies beyond them, exceeding them in dignity and power.

Republic VI, 509b (modern rendering)

Question

Is the Good really like the sun?

3. The Cave: the prisoners

Republic VII, 514a-515c

The opening of the most famous image in Western philosophy. Note the careful staging: chains, the fire behind, the parapet, the puppeteers, the wall on which the shadows fall.

Let me show you, in a picture, how things stand with us in respect of knowledge and ignorance. Imagine people living in an underground cave. Its mouth opens up towards the daylight, and a long passage runs the whole length of it. The people have been there since childhood, their legs and necks chained so that

they can only look straight ahead. The chains stop them turning their heads. Behind and above them, at a distance, a fire is burning. Between the fire and the prisoners, running along the floor, is a raised pathway. Beside it stands a low wall, like the screen behind which puppeteers hide themselves while they show their puppets above it.

Republic VII, 514a–b (modern rendering)

The prisoners' mistake: they take the shadows for the whole of reality.

Now imagine, walking along behind that wall, people carrying all kinds of objects that show over the top — pots, statues of human beings and animals made of wood and stone, every sort of thing. Some of the people are speaking; others are silent. — A strange picture, he said; and strange prisoners. — They are like us, I replied. All they see are the shadows of these objects, and of one another, which the firelight throws on the wall in front of them. They have never seen anything else.

Republic VII, 514b–515a (modern rendering)

Question

Are we like the prisoners?

4. The Cave: the ascent

Republic VII, 515c–516c

One prisoner is released. The release is not gentle: he is dazzled, confused, and at first refuses to believe his new sights are real.

Now consider what would happen if one of them were freed and shown his mistake. Suppose he were forced to stand up suddenly, turn around, walk, and look towards the firelight. All of this would be painful. The glare would dazzle him; he would not be able to make out the real things whose shadows he used to see. And suppose someone told him: what you saw before was an illusion; now, turned towards what is more real, you see things more truly. What would he say in reply?

Republic VII, 515c–d (modern rendering)

The ascent to the sunlit world is staged: shadows first, then reflections, then objects, then the heavens, and finally the sun itself.

His eyes would need time to grow used to the upper world. First he would be able to look only at shadows. Then at the reflections of people and other things in water. Then at the things themselves. After that he would lift his gaze to the

night sky — the moon and stars — which he would find easier to bear than the sun by day. And last of all he would be able to look at the sun itself. Not a reflection of it in water, nor its glow on some other surface, but the sun in its own place, and see it as it really is.

Republic VII, 516a-b (modern rendering)

Question

Why doesn't the freed prisoner immediately see the truth?

5. The Cave: the return

Republic VII, 516e-517a

The freed prisoner must return. The descent is as painful as the ascent. And there is no welcome waiting at the bottom.

Now imagine the same man coming straight out of the sunlight and being put back in his old place. His eyes would be full of darkness. And suppose there were a contest of identifying shadows, and he had to compete with the prisoners who had never moved at all — while his eyes were still useless to him, before they had had time to adjust. He would look ridiculous. They would say of him that the journey upward had ruined his sight, and that it was not worth even thinking of going up. And if anyone tried to free them and lead them up to the light — if they could lay hands on him — they would kill him.

Republic VII, 516e-517a (modern rendering)

The passage that immediately follows offers Plato's own interpretation of the figure — the cave is the world of sight, the light of the fire is the sun within the cave, the ascent is the soul's journey into the intelligible world, and the sun outside is the Good.

This whole picture, dear Glaucon, can now be attached to the argument we had before. The cave is the visible world. The light of the fire is the sun within that world. The journey upward is the soul's ascent into the intelligible. This is my own view — whether it is right or wrong, only the god knows.

Republic VII, 517b (modern rendering)

Question

Why do the prisoners want to kill him when he returns?